

Class 10th | English



First Flight

The Ball Poem

LECTURE - 1

STANZA 1

What is the boy now, who has lost his ball,
What, what is he to do? I saw it go
Merrily bouncing, down the street, and then
Merrily over - there it is in the water!
No use to say 'O there are other balls:

→ happily

LOSS

Poet ↔ small child. → 1st time

↓
value of responsible...

ॐ नमः शिवाय

EXPLANATION

The poem starts with the poet looking at the boy who has lost his ball. The poet wants to know about him and his reaction after losing his ball. The poet himself saw the ball bouncing happily down the street and then, falling into the water. The poet says that there is no use to tell the boy that there are other balls as he would get many other balls but he would never be able to get the lost ball and the memories associated with it back.

STANZA 2

An ultimate shaking ^{sadness} grief fixes the boy
As he stands rigid, trembling, staring down
All his young days into the harbour where
His ball went. I would not intrude on him;
A dime, another ball, is worthless.

Port
↓
ships

disturb

simple

Childhood / innocent nature
of a child.

↓
grown up

EXPLANATION

In these lines, the poet describes the condition of the boy after losing his ball. The boy feels very sad due to the loss of his ball. He is standing like a statue at one place. He is shivering and staring down the ball which symbolises the memories of his young days. The boy is filled with sorrow and just keeps staring in the direction where his ball is going.

The poet says that he would not interfere in the boy's thoughts as he feels that through this experience, the boy will learn the meaning of loss.

According to the poet, it is not worth it to tell the boy that another ball can be bought. This is so because the poet knows that even though the boy can buy another ball, he' would not get the memories attached with the lost ball back. The boy would never get the ball which was with him from his very childhood. Hence, the new ball would be worthless.

STANZA 3

..... Now

He senses first responsibility , loss

In a world of possessions. People will take
Balls, balls will be lost always, little boy.

And no one buys a ball back. Money is external.

AY B
↑

EXPLANATION

In these lines, the poet says that the boy is learning his first responsibility of taking care of his things and how to bear the loss of something in a world of possessions. The poet adds that balls will be lost many times.

In other words, the poet wants to highlight that losses are a part of our lives. Money is external as it can not buy memories nor can it replace the lost things.

STANZA 4

He is learning, well behind his (desperate) eyes,
This epistemology of loss, how to stand up - move on.
Knowing what every man must one day know
And most know many days, how to stand up.

knowledge.

processing in his mind - while looking at the ball

move
on.

loss

↓
grief/sad↓
learn - loss↓
accept↓
move on.

EXPLANATION

In these lines, the poet suggests that from the loss of the ball, the boy is learning the meaning of loss.

He is also learning how to stand up from the loss. The poet says that knowing that every man has to stand up after such losses, the boy too will learn how to stand up and leave the losses behind. He would have understood the true meaning and nature of loss.

Theme



Loss,
loss of childhood & immo.
Learning how to MOVE ON.

POETIC DEVICES

Repetition Repetition of words/phrases in the same line

- What, what
- Balls, balls

Alliteration Repetition of initial consonant sounds in the same line

- What, what
- Balls, balls
- buys a ball back

Metaphor Comparison between two different objects without the use of comparison words.

The lost ball here is a metaphor for the boy's childhood.

With the loss of the ball, the boys's childhood is also lost.

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